The erosion in support for Akhilesh's government was good news for Amit Shah. His UP strategy was working perfectly. SP down and out, Mayawati making no real headway, Rahul missing in action and his party in disarray —Shah's political rehabilitation seemed complete. Well, almost.

In the middle of November, while the country was mourning the retirement of Sachin Tendulkar, 'Snoopgate' hit the headlines. A scandal had broken out, with two websites, Cobrapost.com and Gulail.com, releasing audio tapes with telephone conversations that purportedly had Shah directing the illegal surveillance of a young woman at the behest of his 'saheb'. I was in Mumbai tracking the Sachin mania when the story broke. That evening, I got a call from Shah. His voice was as soft as ever but the message was less comfiting:

'Yeh kya headline story aap chala rahe ho. Thoda zara dekh lo na, hata do usko' (What is this story you are running, please do see and remove it).

I was used to politicians occasionally ringing up, asking for negative stories to be edited out. My standard approach was to say I didn't know what was airing on the channel and that I wasn't in the studio. The hope was always that the politician would forget about it and the sheer pace of a 24/7 news wheel would prevent anyone from trying to put pressure to censor content. Shah, though, seemed pretty insistent, but I wasn't going to be bullied easily. 'Don't worry, sir, you give your version too, story *ko to chalana padega* [I have to run the story],' I said, while asking our news team to be careful with the facts.

By next morning, the story had acquired a momentum of its own. The Congress had found a new stick with which to beat the Shah–Modi duo, this time one that they were hopeful would actually land a decisive political blow. The party's women MPs were summoned to Delhi by Rahul Gandhi's office and asked to hold a special press conference. Women's organizations were particularly irate and demanded Modi's resignation and Shah's prosecution. 'Why doesn't Amit Shah tell us who the "saheb" is on whose behalf he was snooping?' asked the National Commission for Women chairperson, Mamata Sharma. The Central government promised to appoint